languages other than Assamese—mainly Bengali, but also Hindi, Nepali, Oraon, Santali and Munda, the last three being tribal languages from eastern India.

Mass migration would be a major force for political, social, cultural and economic change, often resisted by the indigenous Assamese. Their sense of alienation was further attenuated by the fact that Bengali was the official language of the government when they were part of the Bengal Presidency. Between 1912 and 1947, Assam was a separate chief commissioner's province that included Sylhet district, dominated by Bengali-Muslims. The 1937 elections threw up a minority Muslim League government, stoking Hindu–Muslim tensions on account of proposals to incorporate Assam within Pakistan after Independence. However, the Congress won the elections in 1946 and ensured that Assam was kept out of Pakistan though Sylhet was transferred to Pakistan after a referendum. Since then, the Assamese Hindus in political power passed a raft of regulations in favour of the 'sons of the soil'. For about two decades, the Bengali Muslims were an unspoken coalition partner of the Assamese, even adopting the local language. Collectively, they ran up against the Bengali Hindus over the language options for examinations in educational institutions, an issue that generated a large student-based political movement.

This political understanding was shattered in the late 1970s when a sizable immigration influx was detected from Bangladesh, evidenced by the inflated numbers on the revised electoral roll during elections. Close to 2 million Bengalis from Bangladesh were estimated to have entered Assam between 1971 and 1981.[50] These migrations were partly triggered by the Bangladeshi refugee crisis but, more importantly, were built on social networks laid down in the colonial era, mainly directed towards agricultural settlements. To protest, the dominant political parties led a civil disobedience movement and triggered violent agitations. In February 1983, in what would later be dubbed as the Nellie massacre, hundreds, if not thousands, of Bengali Muslims in villages close to Guwahati were killed and thousands fled to temporary refugee camps. The Nellie massacre remains Independent India's worst episode of anti-migrant violence.